are screaming in horror and rage at the selection list issued by the J&K Board of Professional Entrance Examinations. "Most of them are from one particular community," says BJP leader and Leader of the Opposition in the J&K assembly, Sunil Sharma. "People donate here from across India for Sanatana Dharma and Bharatiya culture."

CONSTITUTIONAL NOVELTY

Soon, Hindu right-wing outfits were picketing the premises. Their demand: cancel the selection list, and reserve admissions for Hindus. By November-end, Sharma formalised this in a meeting with Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha. "We requested that only students with faith and belief in Vaishno Devi be enrolled here," says Sharma. The L-G, who also serves as the shrine board chairman, is looking into the memo.

Strains credulity? Well, the causal panic is real. But Hindu reservations would be a constitutional novelty. The logic sits at the troubled border between spiritual origin and temporal purpose. The Vaishno Devi board was enacted by a 1988 Act of the J&K assembly, while the college owes its resources to donations at the shrine, where yearly footfalls now cross 9 million.

Kashmir's leadership is united in outrage. The CM says any shift from a merit-based policy may be taken to the Supreme Court. "Shall welfare be doled out according to religion? Shall ration shops start asking for religion? Should police work like that?" he asked, daring those who want Hindu quotas to have SMVDIME declared a minority institution. The Opposition, too, was irate: Mehbooba Mufti talked of "anti-Muslim apartheid", Sajad Lone said the BJP is experimenting with communalising the sciences. The National Conference's Tanvir Sadiq tweeted official documents showing grants-in-aid of Rs 24 crore (2024) and Rs 28 crore (2025) to the larger shrine board-run university, SMVDU. This affiliated college had wanted to avail admissions under the central pool but was disallowed.

The Valley has anxieties over J&K's controversial quotas: data shared in the assembly recently reveals Jammuites as big beneficiaries, translating into a disproportionate share of government jobs. A fairly secular domain. ■

Takeaways

- **Kashmiris bag 42 of 50 seats in SMVDIME via NEET**
- **Cancel merit list, reserve all seats for Hindus: BJP-VHP**
- **CM Omar leads outrage in Valley: all have equal right**



DEVOTED TO SCIENCE Part of the new SMVDIME complex in Katra

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

IT'S GOA'S VERSION OF THE *mahagathbandhan*. Luckily, it's called GOA, or the 'Grand Opposition Alliance'. But the mother of all alliances, an idea floated by the Congress, has run into a familiar yet unexpected hurdle: defectors. The project, meant to sink the saffron armada in the assembly election due in 2027, is undergoing its pilot run in a smaller, but no less sterner, laboratory.

On November 29, the State Election Commission announced elections to the North and South Goa zilla panchayats (ZPs). A total of 868,000 people are eligible to vote. How many line up on December 20, and how many of them take a shine to this new alliance, will be clear on counting day: December 22.

A PILOT RUN

The polls are a litmus test for the Pramod Sawant government. If GOA holds its own, it's expected to continue on to its Phase 2 trials: the urban local body polls, due early next year. If it survives that, it will enter the finals a year later.

Assembly polls are due in January-February 2027, and the Congress is intent on bringing together the Goa Forward Party (GFP) and the Revolutionary Goans Party (RGP), a nativist outfit, under the GOA beach umbrella well in time. Both have an MLA each in the 40-member House. In the 2022 state polls, the Congress had shrunk to 11 seats; the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) wrested 20.

That was a tighter haul compared to its 2020 North